Gospel According to Miss Roj

By George C. Wolfe

NOTE: Script indicates that actor should be African American.

{Pg 14-18) *(The darkness is cut by electronic music. Cold, pounding, unrelenting. A neon sign which spells out THE BOTTOMLESS PIT clicks on. There is a lone bar stool. Lights flash on and off, pulsating to the beat. There is a blast of smoke and, MISS ROJ (an African American man) appears. He is dressed in striped patio pants, white go-go boots, a halter, and cat-shaped sunglasses. What would seem ridiculous on anyone else, MISS ROJ wears as if it were high fashion. He carries himself with total elegance and absolute arrogance.)*

MISS ROJ: God created black people and black people created style. The name's Miss Roj . . . that's R.O.J. thank you and you can find me every Wednesday, Friday and Saturday nights at "The Bottomless Pit," the watering hole for the wild and weary which asks the question, "Is there life after Jherri-curl?"

INTRODUCTION

Miss Roj -- a transvestite with some strong coping mechanisms. But despite his humor and other expressions of "attitude." There is a deep river of pain and the struggle to define his own identity. Snapping and dancing become things, not to smile about, but to recognize as cries of a persecuted minority. The Gospel According to Miss Roj by George C. Wolfe

MISS ROJ: Yes, if they be black and swish, the B.P. has seen them, which is not to suggest the Pit is lacking in cultural diversity. Oh no. There are your dinge queens, white men who like their chicken legs dark. *(He winks/flirts with the audience.)* And let's not forget, "Los Muchachos de la Neighborhood." But the speciality of the house is The Snap Queens. *(He snaps his fingers.)* We are a rare breed.

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For, you see, when something strikes our fancy, when the truth comes piercing through the dark, well you just can't let it pass unnoticed. NO darling. You must pronounce it with a snap. *(He snaps.)* Snapping comes from another galaxy, as do all snap queens. That's right. I ain't just your regular oppressed American Negro. No-no—no! I am an extra-terrestial. And I ain't talkin' none of [what] you seen in the movies! I have real power.

Yes, I was placed here on Earth to study the life habits of a deteriorating society, and child when we talkin' New York City, we are discussing the Queen of Deterioration. Miss New York is doing a slow dance with death, and I am here to warn you all, but before I do, I must know . . . don't you just love my patio pants? Annette Funicello immortalized them in "Beach Blanket Bingo," and I have continued the legacy. And my go-gos? I realize white after Labor Day is very gauche, but as the saying goes, if you've got it flaunt it, if you don't, front it and snap to death [anyone who dares to defy you. *(Laughing)* Oh ho! My demons are showing.

Let's just hope for all concerned I dance my demons 'cause child, dancing demons take you on a ride and you find yourself doing the strangest things. Like the time I locked my father in the broom closet. Seems the liquor made his tongue real liberal and he decided he was gonna baptize me with the word "faggot" over and over. Well, he's just going on and on with "faggot this" and "faggot that," all the while walking toward the broom closet. So the demons just took hold of my wedges and forced me to kick [him] into the closet and lock the door. *(Laughter)* Three days later I remembered he was there. *(He snaps.)*

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(Dancing about.) Oh yes—yes—yes! Miss Roj is quintessential style. I corn row the hairs on my legs so that they spell out M.I.S.S. R.O.J. And I dare [anyone] to [mess] with me because I will snap [you] into oblivion. I have the power, you know. Every time I snap, I steal one beat of your heart. So if you find yourself gasping for air in the middle of the night, chances are you [messed] with Miss Roj and she didn't like it.

Like the time this [jerk] at Jones Beach decided to take issue with my coulotte-sailor ensemble. This child, this muscle-bound Brooklyn thug in a skin-tight bikini. You know the kind who beat up on their wives for breakfast. Snap your fingers if you know what I'm talking about . . . Come on and snap, child. Well, he decided to blurt out when I walked by, "Hey look at da monkey in da faggit suit." Well, I walked up to the poor dear, very calmly lifted my hand, and. . . . *(He snaps in rapid succession.)* A heart attack, right there on the beach. You don't believe it? Cross me! Come on! Come on!

(Looking around.) If this place is the answer, we're asking all the wrong questions. The only reason I come here is to communicate with my origins. Theflashing lights are signals from my planet way out there. Yes, girl, even further than Flatbush. We're talking another galaxy. The flashing lights tell me how much time is left before the end.

I hate the people here. But most of all I hate this [damn] music. *(Raps some horrible lyrics)* That ain't music. Give me Aretha Franklin any day. *(Singing)* "Just a little respect. R.E.S.P.E.C.T" Yeah! Yeah!

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Come on and dance with Miss Roj. Last call is [moments] away and each snap puts you one step closer to the end. *(In rap style)* "A high-rise goes up. You can't get no job." Come on everybody and dance. "A whole race of people gets trashed and debased." Snap those fingers and dance. "Some sick [mama] thows her baby out the window 'cause she thinks it's the Devil." Everybody snap! "*The New York Post.*" Snap!

Snap for every time you walk past someone lying in the street and you don't see it. Snap for every crazed [man] who kills himself so as to get the jump on being killed. And snap for every sick [mind] who, bored with carrying around his fear, takes to shooting up other people.

Yeah, snap your fingers and dance with Miss Roj. But don't be fooled by the banners and balloons 'cause, child, this ain't no party going on. Hell no! It's a wake. And the casket's made out of stone, steel and glass and the people are racing all over the pavement like maggots on a dead piece of meat.

Yeah, dance! But don't be surprised if there ain't no beat holding you together 'cause we traded in our drums for respectability. So now it's just words. Words rappin'. Words screechin'. Words flowin' instead of blood 'cause you know that don't work. Words cracklin' instead of fire ' cause by the time a match is struck on 125th Street and you run to mid-town, the flame has been blown away.

So come on and dance with Miss Roj and her demons. We don't ask for acceptance. We don't ask for for approval. We know who we are and we move on it!

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I guarantee you will never hear two fingers put together in a snap and not think of Miss Roj. That's power, baby. Patio pants and all. *(The lights begin to flash in rapid succession.)* So let's dance! And snap! And dance! And snap! *(MISS ROJ begins to dance as if driven by his demons. singing "Respect.")*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
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